नवाः सन्देश
A NSC Newsletter
Newah Society of Calgary
नेवाः सोसाईटी अफ क्यालगरी
वर्ष ५ अंक ९ नेपाल सम्वत ११४६ पोहेला जनवरी २०२६

## Newah Society of Calgary

Newah Society of Calgary (NSC) is a community-based, non-profit organization dedicated to preserving, promoting, and educating Newah language, culture, and traditions in Calgary. The Society plays a significant and vital role in strengthening cultural identity, supporting intergenerational learning, and fostering social inclusion through cultural, educational, and community programs. By actively engaging families, youth, and seniors, the Newah Society contributes to multicultural understanding and enriches the cultural and social life of the Calgary community.

In 2025, Newah Society of Calgary carried out a wide range of cultural, educational, and community-based activities that strongly reflected its goals, vision, and mission. Through language education, cultural celebrations, heritage preservation, community gardening, and collaborative programs with partner organizations, the Society worked to promote and preserve Newah culture, language, and traditions. These activities strengthened community connection, supported intergenerational learning, and contributed to cultural awareness and inclusion within the diverse communities of Calgary.

## NEWS from July to December 2025

- Nepalbhasa School has been operating virtually on a biweekly basis.
- NSC successfully organized a community gathering and summer picnic at North Glenmore Park, bringing together 157 community members in a warm and friendly environment.

- Nepali Mela 2025 was held on July 2, 2025, during which Newah Society of Calgary actively participated with a vibrant cultural rally, jhaki, and traditional dance performances.
- Yenya Punhi (Indra Jatra) was joyfully celebrated by the NSC on September 20, 2025, in the presence of 93 community members, reflecting the rich cultural heritage and unity of the Newah community.
- The 5th Annual General Meeting (AGM) was successfully conducted, where the new Executive Board Committee for the 2025–2027 term was duly formed.
- On October 22, 2025, the Newah Society of Calgary successfully conducted Mhapuja and celebrated Nepal Sambat 1146 in the presence of 105 community members.
- NSC performed Newah Cultural dances in Stampede, Hindu Heritage Month, and 42nd Americas Nepali Association Conference.
- Executive Board members participated in Good Job RAT Meeting, NRNA Canada's Update Meeting, Mt. Everest Day, Learn and Share of Community Climate Change Action.

## Editorial… "Volunteering"

Volunteers play a vital role in the success of the Newah Society of Calgary. Their dedication, time, and skills are essential to delivering cultural, educational, and community programs. Volunteering strengthens community bonds, supports leadership development, and fosters a strong sense of belonging and shared responsibility. The commitment of volunteers directly reflects the Society's vision and mission by promoting cultural preservation, intergenerational learning, and inclusive community engagement, while ensuring that Newah language, culture, and traditions continue to thrive in Calgary.

Volunteers are the backbone of the Newah Society of Calgary, playing a significant role in achieving its vision and mission. Their time, skills, and commitment are essential for preserving and promoting Newah language, culture, and traditions through cultural, educational, and community programs. Volunteering benefits individuals by building leadership skills, fostering a sense of belonging, and strengthening community connections, while also supporting collective growth and cultural continuity.

Looking ahead, volunteers can continue to support the Society by assisting in language classes, cultural events, youth and senior programs, community gardening, administration, and outreach activities. The Newah Society aims to mobilize enthusiastic volunteers by creating inclusive opportunities, providing guidance and skill development, and encouraging active participation in community development initiatives that strengthen cultural identity and social cohesion in Calgary.

## Bhairav Dance

Bhairav holds a significant and sacred place in Newah culture as a powerful manifestation of Lord Shiva, symbolizing protection, strength, justice, and the balance between discipline and compassion. In the Newah community, Bhairav is deeply revered and reflects the rich spiritual heritage, traditional values, and ritual practices that have been passed down through generations. The presence of Bhairav in cultural activities represents the community's commitment to preserving its identity, faith, and ancestral traditions.

Bhairav Dance is an important cultural expression performed during festivals and special community programs. In Calgary, the Bhairav dance has been presented at various cultural events to showcase Newah heritage, engage younger generations, and share the community's traditions with the wider public. These performances play a vital role in promoting cultural awareness, strengthening community pride, and keeping Newah traditions alive in the multicultural landscape of Calgary.

**"Newah heritage lives through language, rituals, and community unity."**

# Nepalbhasa Yesterday, Today and tomorrow!

**Damodar Pradhan, Alberta, Canada**

Nepalbhasa is the language spoken by Newah indigenous people from Nepal, is one of the oldest and richly cultured languages, and uses nine different scripts. None of these scripts is in use today to write Nepalbhasa but two scripts Ranjana (the decorative script) and Prachalit Nepal Lipi (The commonly used script resembling the Devanagari Script) are used in computer typing that has been decoded into computer. Devanagari, the borrowed script used these days to write Nepalbhasa, which does not belong to the Newah community. Newah are the original inhabitants from Kathmandu Valley also found scattered all over Nepal. Newah migrated to all big and small cities outside Kathmandu and around the Globe.

During the early days of Nepalese history, Nepalbhasa was widely used as the official language of Nepal, the treaties between Nepal and Tibet written in Nepalbhasa. We find many manuscripts, stone inscriptions and official documents written in Nepalbhasa until before the unification of the country in 1767 AD. After the victory over Kathmandu valley by Prithivi Narayan Shah, the ruler suppressed Nepalbhasa, people were not able to read and speak their Native language. Those who try to revolt against the rule are tortured, imprisoned or forced to leave the country. Nepalbhasa was under the strict control of the Government for more than a Century, Nepali language being declared as the official language, Nepali speakers given better preference by the government, and many people left speaking Nepalbhasa. The Shah rulers under the Brahmin priest's instructions made Nepalbhasa literature and Buddhist manuscripts are collected and burnt in the crossroad. During the century-old Rana autocratic family rule, they tried to destroy Nepalbhasa literature along with Buddhist manuscripts collected from the Newah family and burnt. Brian Houghton Hodgson, the British resident in Kathmandu (1833-1843) was able to save hundreds of ancient manuscripts written in Nepalbhasa and distribute them to many Museums and libraries. We are now able to use those……. manuscripts, which were about to be burned by the Shah and Rana Rulers.

After the revolution liquidating the century old Rana ruling in 1950, a new renaissance started in the development of Nepalbhasa literature, again the government-imposed sensor in Nepalbhasa activity and imposed restriction in Nepalbhasa program including the Nepalbhasa News telecast in Radio. Newah speakers fight to protect and preserve their language, and activists have been jailed, exiled and tortured by the government.

Among the middle class Newah family, they feel proud of speaking Nepali instead of their mother tongue, Nepalbhasa. Even outside the ring road, in the small Newah communities, they started speaking Nepali language within their family, slowly and gradually Newah speakers are getting lesser day by day.

David Gellner, the British Professor of Social Anthropology, who devoted many years studying Nepalbhasa and Newah culture, claimed, if necessary, action is not taken, it would be hard to find people speaking Nepalbhasa after fifty years. He is worried about saving and preserving Nepalbhasa not to get declared to be a dead language. (https://youtu.be/4RfjT80klsO?si=XfJLo1mz5xO53cKY)

UNESCO already predicted 1,500 endangered languages could disappear by the end of the century. Digital solutions could help preserve the world's endangered languages including Nepalbhasa. In order to save indigenous language spoken by lesser communities, UNESCO started digitizing many indigenous languages, declared 2019 as the international year of Indigenous Language, and passed a resolution to mark the International Decade of Indigenous Languages (2022-2032). This program is aiming to engage the global community with the critical issue of language loss, focused on protecting the rights of indigenous people to revitalize and preserve their languages.

Nepal Government also passed a resolution to protect indigenous language by making it mandatory in the School to teach in the dialect spoken by the community. Nowadays one can study Nepalbhasa in the Tribhuvan University in Kathmandu and obtain higher Degree, MPhil and PHD.

**Nepalbhasa in the International field**

In many countries, where there is a dense population of Newah migrants live, a group of youngsters are organizing a summer class teaching Nepalbhasa to the youngsters as well as parents who do not speak Nepalbhasa.

1) International Standard Organization (ISO) registered Nepalbhasa in their Data Base 2004 and finalized with a review in 2007 as ISO 639-3 new (Newah Bhaye). The International reorganization for Nepalbhasa could be granted with the reference to Lankavatara Sutra (AD 903) written in Palm tree Bark written in Nepalbhasa in Bhojimol script.

2) Nepalbhasa Wikipedia (www.new.wikipedia)
With the ISO listing, Wikipedia also granted permission to get Nepalbhasa language edition of the free encyclopedia that has 72,822 articles listed until 2024.

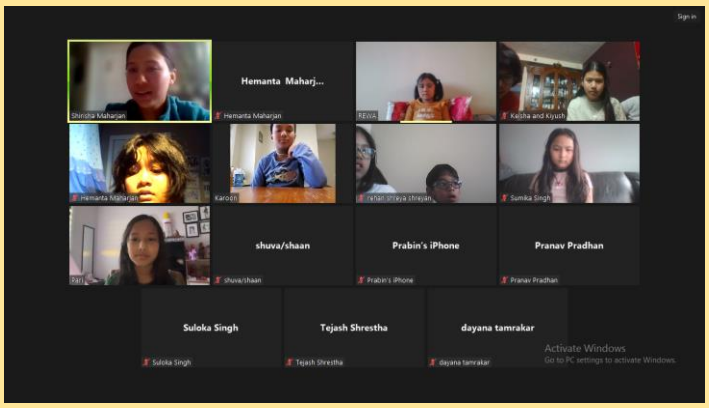
3) The World Newah Organization organized a group of volunteers to contribute and help Google Computer to learn Nepalbhasa. In 2024, Google translation granted permission to list Nepalbhasa in their translation service. Now it is easy to use Google translation service to translate between Nepalbhasa and 135 different languages spoken around the Globe.
https://new.wikipedia.org, https://new.wikipedia.org/wiki/मु-पौ

4) With the financial support provided by Kathmandu Municipality, Nepalbhasa Academy recently published five big volumes of Newah Cultural Encyclopedia in Nepalbhasa (Nepalbhasa Gyankosh). The digital edition of this publication is in progress, one can easily read the online edition soon. Nepalbhasa Academy is also trying to get it translated into Nepali and English language. Once the Nepali and English editions are published, anyone can easily access Newah culture.
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OOLwT-Xz2RO

With all the effort made by lots of different individuals, Newah and Non-Newah who speak Nepalbhasa and Newah activists, Nepalbhasa, also known as Newah Bhye and Newari language is going to get preserved forever!
Let us cross our fingers and thank all individuals and Newah activists who contributed their effort revitalizing and preserving Nepalbhasa!

## Nepalbhasa (Newah Language) Class

Newah Society of Calgary has made a generous and dedicated effort to educate and preserve Nepalbhasa by supporting Newah children in understanding and speaking Newah words and sentences. This initiative has successfully improved their language capacity and communication skills, with a significant impact seen in their ability to communicate within their family circle, connect with relatives living in Nepal, and confidently interact with seniors in the Newah community. Shirisha Maharjan has been continuously volunteering as an instructor, playing a vital role in the promotion, preservation, education, and transfer of Nepalbhasa to the new generation.




**"Our traditions connect us to our ancestors, and our culture guides us toward the future—this is the spirit of Newah heritage."**

# Nepali Mela – 2025

Nepali Mela 2025, held in July 19, 2025 at Prairie Winds Park, was a significant multicultural event celebrating Nepali culture, heritage, and unity within Calgary's diverse community. The Mela provided an important platform for cultural exchange, community connection, and the promotion of inclusion and harmony among different communities.

Newah Society of Calgary, an active participant in the Nepali Mela since 2023, proudly contributed to the 2025 celebration. The Society presented 120 Newah members in the rally and Jhaki (cultural procession), showcasing traditional Newah attire, identity, and heritage. In addition, Newah cultural dances were performed, highlighting the richness of Newah culture and engaging audiences of all backgrounds.

Participation in Nepali Mela 2025 reflected the Newah Society of Calgary's ongoing commitment to preserving and promoting Newah culture, encouraging community pride, and strengthening multicultural understanding across Calgary.

## Executive Board Committee (2025–2027)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Hemanta Maharjan** | - | President |
| **Arun Shrestha** | - | Vice President |
| **Pradyumn Shrestha** | - | General Secretary |
| **Roshi Shrestha** | - | Treasurer |
| **Pooja Shrestha** | - | Joint Secretary |
| **Rabi Talchabhadel** | - | Member |
| **Diana Tamrakar** | - | Member |
| **Shirisha Maharjan** | - | Member |
| **Pallavi Singh** | - | Member |

# Mhapuja and Nepal Sambat 1145

Mhapuja, the unique Newah tradition of self-worship, marks the beginning of Nepal Sambat 1146 and symbolizes self-respect, spiritual purification, prosperity, and unity. For the Newah community, Mhapuja is a deeply meaningful cultural practice that honors the self as sacred and promotes balance between body, mind, and society. Celebrating Nepal Sambat also reflects the rich historical identity, values, and calendar system of the Newah people.

For the wider communities in Calgary, this celebration serves as an important opportunity for cultural sharing, mutual understanding, and intercultural harmony. It creates space for learning about Newah heritage, traditions, and philosophies, strengthening multicultural connections within the city.

The event is especially beneficial for the new generation, as it helps educate youth about their roots, language, rituals, and cultural values, ensuring the transfer and preservation of Newah culture for future generations.

The Newah Society of Calgary proudly organized the Mhapuja and Nepal Sambat 1146 celebration on October 22, 2025, at the Crossroads Community Association. A total of 95 participants attended the event, making it a successful and meaningful cultural gathering that reinforced community bonds and cultural pride.

NEWAH SOCIETY OF CALGARY 2021

**Newah Society of Calgary (NSC)**

Community based non-profit organization established by the ethnic Newah people, the indigenous inhabitants of the Kathmandu Valley in Nepal.

**Vision:**

A vibrant, harmonious, and cohesive *Newah* Community within Calgary's diverse and multicultural environment.

**Mission:**

Preserving, promoting, educating, transferring, and revitalizing *Nepalbhasa* (*Newah* Language), *Newah* culture, tradition, and heritage.

**Activities:**

- Run *Nepalbhasa* classes and research.
- Organize cultural events.
- Conduct orientations, trainings, and mentorship programs.
- Celebrate festivals, ceremonies, and rituals.
- Host awareness campaigns.
- Engage in community development and humanitarian activities.
- Maintain *Si Bicha* (death ritual) *Guthi*.

NEWAH SOCIETY OF CALGARY

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NEWAH SOCIETY OF CALGARY 2021

**Promotion, Preservation, Education and Revitalization of Nepalbhasa (Newah Language), Newah Culture, Tradition and Heritage**

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